EDUCATIONPLUS

Build the right connections

Strengthening institutional capacity, measuring outcomes reliably and using better regional data can create more opportunities for all learners

Mamidala Jagadesh Kumar

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India's higher education system faces two challenges at once. A qualification earned in one part of the country should be recognised and respected elsewhere but the education offered must also be relevant to its students, languages, social setting, and surrounding economy. These aims may appear to pull in different directions. In practice, they can reinforce each other.

This balance is the essence of the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020, which makes responsiveness to India's diversity and local conditions a guiding principle for curriculum, teaching, and policy. It calls for careful planning, joint monitoring, and collaboration between the Centre and the States, supports institutional autonomy and the expansion of programmes in local languages, and provides meaningful room for State priorities and local aspirations.

Guidelines

National frameworks provide broad guidelines to the institutions without imposing rigid prescriptions. For instance, the UGC framework leaves important academic decisions to institutional statutory bodies. Boards of Studies and Academic Councils can determine course lists and allocate credits across different programme structures.

Thus, the frameworks focus on achieving the desired learning outcomes rather than imposing uniformity across every syllabus or subject combination.

NEP 2020 seeks to remove rigid separations among arts, sciences and vocational learning while preserving disciplinary depth. New interdisciplinary programmes can build confidence over time alongside established ones. Institutions are best placed to undertake this patient work.

Recent commentary on regional higher-education needs has rightly emphasised that admission patterns must be understood in their regional context. This local perspective can work within, rather than against, a national framework for academic mobility. Such data can reveal demand within a particular institution or region but they must be interpreted carefully.

A student's choice is also an exercise of agency. Career information should broaden that choice, not prescribe a single "correct" course based on short-term market trends. The All India Survey on Higher Education (AISHE) 2023-24 records 4.50 crore students, compared with 3.42 crore in 2014-15. Over the same period, the gross enrolment ratio for the 18-23 age group rose from 23.7 to 30. These gains indicate an expanding social base. They are useful for building measures for flexibility, inclusion, and regional capacity.

Beyond course preferences, institutional reputation will continue to influence student decisions. Reputation may reflect teaching and research, but also history, location, alumni, programme range, and public visibility. A constructive approach is to widen the number of institutions that students and families can choose with confidence.

Student mobility

At the same time, local relevance should not confine a learner to the place of study. The National Credit Framework and the Academic Bank of Credits seek to make academic, vocational and experiential learning recognisable and portable across institutions and States. Institutions must ensure that credits are accurately recorded, transferred, and redeemed to enable students to complete their programmes promptly. When these arrangements work well, portability and place-based learning support student mobility.

A related question concerns the relationship between curriculum and employment. Degrees cannot be designed only around immediate job openings because economies and occupations change. Higher education must build knowledge, judgement, communication, creativity, and the capacity to learn. It should also give students opportunities to apply those capabilities in professional, social, and community settings. NEP 2020's emphasis on multidisciplinary learning, internships, vocational exposure and local opportunity mapping brings these purposes together.

The UGC's guidance enables institutions to develop internship projects suited to their academic programmes and the surrounding economic environment. Its university-industry framework encourages regional clusters, Industry Relations Cells and engagement with micro, small, and medium enterprises. Apprenticeship-embedded degree programmes and Professors of Practice provide further channels for professional participation. AICTE's model curricula and applied-learning initiatives similarly connect technical education with projects, internships and emerging fields. These mechanisms respect the academic role of institutions while bringing employers and practitioners into appropriate parts of the learning process.

Accordingly, we should continue to build a stronger evidence base linking education to opportunity. From graduating students, institutes could collect information on employment, further study, entrepreneurship, location, wages, and the use of skills at suitable intervals after graduation, while respecting privacy issues. They should also present student-facing programme information, such as curriculum, costs, eligibility, accreditation, internships, completion, and possible pathways, in clear language, without making predictive promises. States and regional skills centres could bring together official labour data, apprenticeship information, industry evidence and institutional records. This can help students and families, institutions, employers and States make better decisions.

Ultimately, India needs a connected education system in which qualifications are recognised across regions. Institutions should adapt to local needs, while students should be free to choose their learning pathways. We should continue to strengthen institutional capacity, measure outcomes reliably and use better regional data. NEP 2020 provides us with a path to develop national frameworks that focus on local relevance to create better opportunities for all learners.

Views are personal

The writer is the Chairman of the Review Committee for NEP 2020 and Chairman, BoG, IIM-Calcutta.

SCHOLARSHIPS

Nikon Scholarship
An initiative by Nikon
Eligibility: Indian citizen who has passed class 12 (any stream) and is currently pursuing a professional photography-related course of minimum three-month duration and an annual parental income not exceeding ₹600,000
Rewards: Based on actual course fee.
Application: Online
Deadline: August 24
www.b4s.in/edge/NIKON14

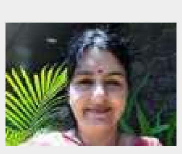
CSIR-NIScPR Internship
Offered by the CSIR-NIScPR
Eligibility: Indian citizens pursuing a UG, PG, or doctoral programme in a recognised institution and demonstrate interest in science communication, policy research, or a related interdisciplinary field.
Rewards: Certificate
Application: Online
Deadline: Round the year
www.b4s.in/edge/NISC1

IIRS External Student Internship Programme
Offered by the IIRS
Eligibility: Indian nationals who have a UG, PG, or Ph.D. degree in Science or Technology from recognised institutions with minimum 60% aggregate.
Rewards: Certificate
Application: Online
Deadline: October 30
www.b4s.in/edge/IIRS2

Courtesy: Buddy4study.com

Shift the focus

Uncertain about your career options? Low on self-confidence? This column may help



OFF THE EDGE
Nandini Raman

I am in Class 12 (Science Stream). I want to be an IAS officer but have social anxiety and stage fear. My English communication is also weak, though I read an English newspaper daily. How can I tackle this? Ramesh

Dear Ramesh,

You do not need to be an extroverted English orator to become an exceptional officer. You have ample time to fix the gaps. Reading an English newspaper daily is great. Your bottleneck, perhaps, is active English (speaking and writing). Start reading one editorial out loud daily. Watch English news analyses or speech clips. Listen to a sentence, pause it, and try to repeat it with the same intonation. This builds linguistic confidence. The UPSC Prelims and Mains test your ability to analyse complex data, maintain focus, and write thoughtful, structured answers.

Social anxiety and stage fear can be unlearned through gradual exposure. Start by talking to the teacher in a small class, participating in a four-person GD, giving a three-minute presentation to friends, and then presenting to the entire class. Shift the focus from 'Me' to the 'Content'. Right now, focus on your Class 12 board exams. In college, join clubs, practise basic UPSC answer writing and take baby steps in public speaking. The UPSC Personality Test looks for honesty, administrative logic and integrity, not loud showmanship.

I am a Class 11 Bio-Maths student. I find the field of Earth, Environmental, and Sustainability Studies highly interesting. Which are the top institutes in India and abroad with a focus on research and teaching careers? What are the other career options? Lena

Dear Lena,

Environmental Science relies on mathematical modelling of climate systems, physical principles of fluid dynamics, chemical analysis of pollutants, and biological insights into ecosystems. Your combination of Biology and Maths is ideal. Since your goal is research and academia, target premier institutes that emphasise experimental design, field studies, and data analysis. In India, the gold standard is an integrated BS-MS or Bachelor of Science (Research) programme.

The Indian Institute of Science, Bengaluru, offers a four-year B.Sc. (Research) programme with a major in Earth and Environmental Science. IISERs across Pune, Kolkata, Mohali, Bhopal, and Thiruvananthapuram have outstanding Earth and Climate Sciences departments. IIT Bombay offers an Interdisciplinary Programme in Climate Studies, while IIT Kharagpur has a five-year integrated M.Sc. in Applied Geology and Earth Sciences. JNU and BHU are strong options for postgraduate research.

If you aim to study abroad, consider Stanford, Columbia, and UC Berkeley in the U.S., Oxford and Cambridge in the U.K., ETH Zurich in Switzerland, and Wageningen University in the Netherlands.

High-demand niches in academics include Climate Modelling and Simulation, Biogeochemistry, Palaeoclimatology, and Satellite Remote Sensing and GIS. Alternative careers include corporate sustainability, think tanks, and international bodies such as UNEP, the World Bank, IPCC and WWF, and the green technology industry.

I am in the third year of medical college and under pressure to crack NEET-PG in the first attempt. I face problems with consistency and time-management. How can I overcome this? Shreeya

Dear Shreeya,

You are starting your focused preparation at the perfect time. You can now build your core clinical concepts without the hectic schedule of a final-year internship. Shift from a 'time-based' to a 'task-based' approach. Hospital schedules and exhaustion can break your schedule. So, use micro-targets. Commit to 20–30 high-yield MCQs and three video modules/textbook topics per day. Utilise 'dead time' and keep your Q-Bank app active.

Focus on mastering your third-year subjects while maintaining a baseline touch with previous years. Ophthalmology, ENT and Community Medicine (PSM) account for a significant chunk of the exam. Spend weekends revising Pathology, Pharmacology and Microbiology from second year.

Break the cycle of procrastination with mini-tests and mock exams. Solve 10–15 MCQs, followed by 45–50 minutes of Targeted Review. Bookmark, tag, and flag volatile facts for weekly review. Ignore the 'Herd Noise'. Follow your path. Perfectionism is the enemy of consistency. It is better to do 20 high-quality MCQs than rush through 100 passively. Finally, a skipped day isn't a failure. Reset and hit your daily minimum target the next morning.

I am in Class 10 and want to pursue Maths for higher studies. But I do not want to continue with Science subjects in Class 11 and 12. What else can I do so that I can study Maths later? Palash

Dear Palash,

There is a misconception that if you want to study higher-level Maths, you must choose Science. Maths is also deeply intertwined with Economics, Commerce, Data Science, and the Social Sciences.

After Class 10, you can choose Commerce or the Humanities and select Maths as an elective. Commerce and Maths open doors to finance, actuarial science and quantitative fields, while Humanities and Maths are useful for public policy, demographic research and economics.

CBSE offers Core Maths covering calculus, trigonometry and algebra, and Applied Maths focussed on business, economics, finance and data analysis. Check the eligibility criteria for your preferred degree before choosing. After Class 12, you can pursue degrees through CUET, including B.Sc./B.A. Mathematics, Actuarial Science, Economics, Data Science and Statistics.

Modern Economics is highly mathematical, while Data Science combines Maths, programming and analytics. Choose the stream that matches your interests.

Disclaimer: This column is merely a guiding voice and provides advice and suggestions on education and careers.

The writer is a practising counsellor and a trainer. Send your questions to eduplus.thehindu@gmail.com with the subject line Off the Edge

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Chance to explore

Why summer schools are the missing link between school and university

Vinnie Mathur

Every year, thousands of students find themselves facing one of the first major decisions of their lives: what to study after school. They compare universities, browse course brochures and speak to family, teachers, and friends. Yet, many make these choices without ever experiencing what those subjects actually look like beyond the classroom.

More options

This challenge has become even more relevant now, as students have more academic options than ever before. Interdisciplinary learning is also becoming increasingly common, allowing students to combine different interests and build unique academic journeys. The National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 has further accelerated this shift by encouraging multidisciplinary learning and greater flexibility in academic pathways. But all this also raises an important question. How can students make informed decisions about fields they have never had the opportunity to experience?

This is where summer schools are beginning to play a far more meaningful role than they did in the past. Traditional summer schools were viewed as a way for students to learn a new skill, pursue a hobby or stay productively engaged during their summer break.

Now, however, they have the potential to become spaces where students can explore varied disciplines, interact with experts and gain a first-hand understanding of university-style learning before making important academic decisions. Interestingly, most students who join these programmes are not looking for certainty but for clarity. They want to test an interest, discover something new or simply understand whether a particular subject excites them enough to pursue it further.

Option to explore

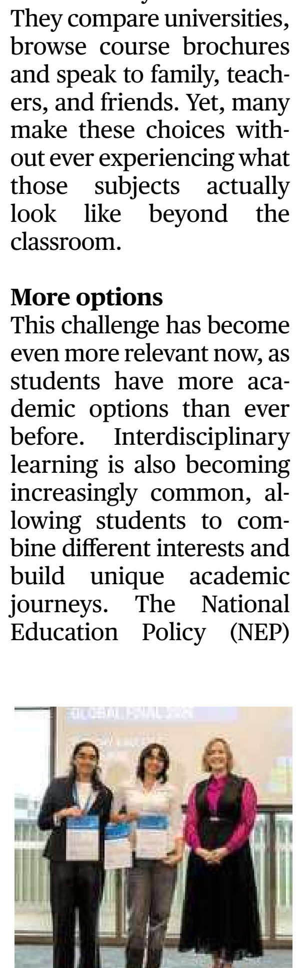
That exploration often begins with a simple change in the learning environment. A design challenge, a laboratory experiment or a discussion on a contemporary issue can reveal dimensions of a subject that are difficult to capture within the structure of a school curriculum. Students quickly realise that learning at the university level is often less about memorising answers and more about questioning assumptions, testing ideas and connecting knowledge across disciplines.

Equally valuable is the opportunity to experience university life before becoming part of it. Questions that begin with admissions requirements or career prospects often evolve into discussions about research, innovation, emerging technologies and the future of work. Summer schools also allow students to engage with current university students, visit laboratories and experience campus life first-hand.

Another important advantage is the opportunity to learn alongside peers from different schools, cities, and backgrounds. Conversations during group projects, meals and informal interactions often end up presenting these students with a new looking glass, and letting them think beyond their existing purview even after the programme ends.

As higher education becomes increasingly interdisciplinary and dynamic, helping students navigate the transition from school to university has never been more important. Summer school allows exploration, encourages curiosity, builds confidence, and allows students to ask better questions about their interests, abilities and aspirations. In many ways, that may be its greatest contribution. Not helping students find all the answers, but helping them discover the questions that matter most before they take their next step.

The writer is Chair of the Young Thinkers Forum, Shiv Nadar University Delhi-NCR.



Win for India

Team Reviv3D — Vidushee, Shravya, and Shloka, students of Mallya Aditi International School, Bengaluru — took the first place at the global finals of Monash University's Change It Challenge in Melbourne.

The team — represented in Melbourne by Vidushee and Shravya — developed affordable, high-quality prosthetics by combining bagasse – the dry, pulpy fibrous material remaining after sugarcane or sorghum stalks are crushed to extract their juice – and crushed basalt from stone with recycled plastics. This composite material is stronger than many fiberglass alternatives, drastically cheaper, and fully recyclable.

Star struck

Why Indian Astronomy education needs a makeover

Smriti Mahajan

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A modern astronomer is as much a physicist as a programmer. Research in Astronomy relies equally on observations and computer clusters for data processing, simulations and data analysis. Tools like Python, IRAF, AstroPy, and machine learning pipelines are basic skills in global observatories and research groups. Yet Indian undergraduates arrive at postgraduate programmes having never run a script or ever heard about a FITS file. Most students at universities never get any exposure to actual research practices in Astronomy. Orbital mechanics is taught through equations on paper, and stellar evolution from textbooks. This structural handicap in Astronomy education is entirely preventable through curriculum reform.

Modern astronomy research is based on three founding pillars: observations (data collection), computation (data processing and modelling), and data analysis (physical interpretation of trends in statistical datasets such as SDSS, GAIA, or India's own AstroSat). At Australian and British universities, it is common for students to run simulations on GADGET, MESA or custom Python frameworks. Data from most large surveys such as the SDSS are publicly available to be used for such projects. Experiential learning, which strengthens intuition, requires familiarisation with the sky and the machine.

At many universities around the world, students can choose a dedicated B.Sc. Physics with Astrophysics specialisation from year one or a standalone B.Sc. Astronomy programme featuring mandatory observation projects, computational labs, and supervised research theses. The pedagogy is learn-by-doing, and theory is taught through practice.

Problems in India

India, however, does not have a standalone undergraduate degree in Astronomy. The closest approximation is the BS-MS programme at IISERs and NISER, but these are broadly Physics degrees with an optional Astrophysics specialisation in the final years. The University of Delhi, Pune University, and Osmania University offer Astrophysics electives but without a structured, progression-mapped pathway. Therefore, students aiming to become astronomers must first obtain a Physics degree, qualify for a national entrance exam such as JEST or CSIR-NET and then enter an Astronomy-specific programme. The current system treats Astronomy as a postgraduate specialisation rather than a foundational discipline because of the belief that Physics is the foundation of Astronomy.

While not completely false, it has become a rigid policy position, leading to astronomy enthusiasts studying subjects like solid-state physics and quantum mechanics, whether these serve their aspirations or not. A progressively designed undergraduate astronomy programme could give students an opportunity to study subjects like stellar spectroscopy, galaxy dynamics and cosmology, which are better aligned with their choices.

India's dedicated astronomy research institutions such as IUCAA and NCRA-TIFR (Pune), ARIES (Nainital), TIFR (Mumbai), IIA, HRI and RRI (Bengaluru) are excellent by global standards, but undergraduate access to this infrastructure is almost nonexistent. ARIES conducts occasional workshops. IIA has a summer school for advanced undergraduates. Only around 100 students across the country get meaningful exposure to frontier astronomy research before their postgraduation. This creates a profound inequality. Students from big cities, with better faculty networks and information access, fill these slots while others are left out. The talent pool is being culled even before it is formed.

Way forward

A credible reform agenda has several components. The IISERs and central universities should launch B.Sc. Astronomy programmes with Maths, Physics, and Computing taught together at the foundation level. India's existing telescopes – the 2m HCT at Hanle, the 1.2m MIRO in Gujarat, Devasthal Observatory in Uttarakhand – can be networked into a national telescope programme, giving students across the country remote observing access. Researchers from institutions like IIA and IUCAA can anchor open online courses in Indian languages to lower the access barrier. Public data archives of missions like AstroSat could be integrated into the undergraduate curriculum, transforming students from consumers of knowledge into producers of it. Industry partnerships with ISRO and HEIs could fund new positions, instruments, and student slots, imparting requisite skills from early days.

Currently, India's scientific ambitions, evidenced by Chandrayaan, AstroSat, and the forthcoming NLST, do not have a matching educational pipeline. Building it is crucial for our future space aspirations.

The writer is Director of Educational Partnerships at Starscapes.

YOUNG ACHIEVER

Every point counts

On winning the gold in the European Girls Olympiad in Informatics 2026

Swasti Vitthal Patil

I first came across algorithmic problem-solving in 2023 after taking a course in Theoretical Computer Science. I was immediately drawn to the subject because every problem felt like a puzzle with its own hidden structure. What I enjoyed most is that solving a problem rarely comes from writing more code; it comes from finding the right observation, identifying a pattern, or examining it from a different angle. Since then, I have been participating in the Informatics Olympiads, progressing through the different stages and competing at the national level. In 2025, I was selected to represent India at the European Girls' Olympiad in Informatics (EGOI), where I won bronze.

This year, after a series of national contests, training camps, and team selection tests, I was selected as one of four students to represent India at EGOI 2026, held in Cesenatico, Italy. The Indian team was supported by Sasken Technologies and the two-day competition took place over two days with contestants solving challenging algorithmic problems that required creativity and logical thinking. We had five hours each day to solve four problems and code solutions, which were evaluated on correctness and efficiency.

On the first day, I solved the first two problems in around an hour and switched between the other two problems, trying to optimise my solutions for both. I was able to get a decent number of points on the third problem, but was worried about the fourth one. Eventually, I came up with an idea worth 11 points, though I wasn't sure if it would make a difference. But I spent the last 30 minutes implementing it. I was ranked 15th at the end of Day 1 and had a chance to bring home the gold.

On Day 2, I was very nervous but managed to finish just three points above the cutoff to win the gold. The 11 points from Day 1 made the difference between gold and silver. I also learnt that every point matters and that a solution does not have to be perfect to be valuable.

Beyond the competition, the event gave me the opportunity to meet students from more than 50 countries, be part of an amazing delegation, and interact with others who shared a passion for Computer Science and problem-solving. Despite the contest's competitive nature, I also learnt about the experiences and perspectives of the other contestants. One interesting discussion about culture and language took place over pizza at a cafe. It was fascinating to hear how differently people experienced the same culture depending on where they grew up. From discussing different views on the problems, interacting with the sponsors, to going for excursions and having gelato on the beach, we made lifelong memories.

While the gold medal was a highlight, what I value most is the training and the opportunity to meet students from around the world who share the same interests. I hope more girls from India pursue and excel in STEM fields in the years ahead.

Team India scores

The other members of Team India also made their mark. Mansi Sane from Mumbai won a silver medal, Diya Sathishdev from Chennai brought home a bronze medal, and Lyra Gonsalves from Mumbai received an honourable mention.

The writer is a home-schooled student based in Pune.

(Left to right): Diya, Lyra, Swasti. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Decoding the future

Competitive programming (CP) reveals technical talent that exams, colleges, and recruiters overlook

Deepak Kumar Gour

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India trains engineers at a scale few countries can match but identifies its best engineers through entrance exam ranks, college brands, and placement package. These are incomplete signals. AI systems, distributed infrastructure, cybersecurity, and core computing require people who can reason through problems that have no textbook answer. India has those people but is not yet very good at finding them. India has never won a gold medal at the International Collegiate Programming Contest (ICPC) World Finals. That gap is not a talent problem but a system one.

Competitive programming (CP) is one of the clearest tools to find deep technical talent. Contests like the ICPC and the International Olympiad in Informatics (IOI) test algorithmic reasoning, mathematical intuition, problem decomposition, and correctness under strict constraints. These are capabilities that sit at the centre of the most demanding technical work being done today.

Public record

What makes CP particularly useful as a career signal is not just what it measures but how it measures it. A student's contest history, rating progression, and topic spread create a public, longitudinal record of how they handle difficulty and improve over time. Most resumes offer nothing close to this. A 2025 study on Codeforces users attempted to quantify exactly this, using contest participation and performance data to classify programmers into employability levels, including readiness for top-tier technology roles.

Countries that perform consistently well in international programming contests have not stumbled into that position. Russia has Olympiad-style training built into its school system. China runs structured national camps. Bangladesh, with far fewer resources than India, has developed a community-led culture that produces world-ranked programmers year after year. The common pattern is not talent. It is structure: early exposure, mentorship, institutional continuity, and recognition. India has pockets of this culture, but not a system.

Early start

The structural gaps show up at every level. Most students encounter CP late, often only because a motivated senior happened to build a community at their college. When those students graduate, the knowledge goes with them. School-level exposure to algorithmic thinking is rare. Industry has not built the vocabulary to recognise CP achievements the way it recognises a college brand or a placement statistic.

Some things are beginning to shift. IIT-Kanpur set aside six Computer Science seats through Olympiad routes. In the first intake, five students entered this way, and all five chose Computer Science. Initiatives like GoForGold point to another part of the answer: structured environments where students can develop this signal through contests, camps, mentorship, and year-round preparation.

But for a country of India's scale, schools need to introduce algorithmic thinking early. Universities need to support CP communities with faculty guidance and continuity across batches. Industry needs to train recruiters to recognise a regional ICPC finalist for what that achievement actually represents. India does not need to replace JEE or dismiss the college hierarchy; it needs to broaden how it reads technical promises. JEE measures academic reasoning, placements and employability. CP reveals whether a student can take an unfamiliar problem, reduce it to its essential structure, and implement a correct solution under constraints.

That capacity is what the next phase of technology will demand most. The question is whether India's talent identification systems are being built for that future, or whether they are still optimised for the one we are leaving behind.

The writer is Associate Director of Academics, Newton School of Technology .

CAREER CUES

Richa Dwivedi Saklani

A selective approach

Trends and insights from the last admission season

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As the dust settles on admissions every year, many trends and signals come to light, telling us what's changing, what students are misunderstanding, and where the real opportunities are hiding. Here's what happened across the U.S., the U.K., and India and what it means going forward.

The U.S.

The test is back. Harvard, MIT, Yale, Stanford, Dartmouth, Brown, Caltech, Georgetown, and Johns Hopkins have all reinstated mandatory SAT or ACT requirements. The test-optional era, which gave students breathing room during the pandemic and its aftermath, is effectively over. Even where it says "optional", it's usually not so for international students.

While a strong SAT score gives an Indian student a number that admissions officers can read and trust, preparation cannot begin a few months before applications. With nearly 784,000 students submitting test scores during the 2025-26 cycle, an 11% increase from the previous year, the competition for strong scores has intensified.

Meanwhile, the average acceptance rate across all Ivy League schools has dropped from 7.2% for the Class of 2024 to just 5.4% for the Class of 2029.

However, a new cohort of elite institutions has emerged as academically rigorous and genuinely excellent, with strong career outcomes and, for many students, a more realistic and more strategically sound target than fixating on Ivy League schools.

The lesson has been: plan earlier, take the SAT seriously, and build a list that is genuinely balanced, not top-heavy.

The Common Application data also shows a shift in how students are applying. Since the 2021-22 cycle, Early Action applications have grown faster than any other decision round, increasing by 7% this year to more than 3.4 million applications.

For competitive candidates, early deadlines are the default approach, so those waiting for the Regular Decision find themselves in an increasingly crowded and competitive pool.

So, a successful application can no longer be built close to the deadlines. Essays, recommendation letters, testing, extracurricular achievements and university research ... all need to be complete by the beginning of the final year of school to apply for early rounds.

The U.K.

The U.K. picture is also quite complex, with the total number of international students falling by 6.1% in 2024-25, driven mostly by visa policy changes.

While applications from Indian students fell for a second consecutive year, international undergraduate applications through UCAS hit a record high jumping 7.1% between 2025 and 2026. Indians haven't stopped looking at the U.K.; they have become more selective about choosing it.

The most competitive UK universities still attract strong international interest. It's the mid- and lower-ranked institutions that students are no longer applying to.

Also, a three-year degree in the U.K., even at a good university, costs significantly less overall than a four-year American degree, and the outcomes in certain fields, particularly Law, Economics, and Humanities, are excellent.

India

Universities like Ashoka, Plaksha, Krea, Shiv Nadar, and FLAME are redefining Indian undergraduate education by offering flexible curricula, interdisciplinary majors, and a strong emphasis on real-world application and are great options for students not choosing to go abroad for undergraduate studies.

Looking at all three systems – the U.S., the U.K., and India – what can be seen is that students who secured genuinely good admits last cycle almost universally had two things: a profile built over multiple years and a list built with actual knowledge of their options rather than a shortlist of famous names. The students who struggled across all three systems had invested heavily in one path, without a serious plan B. Or they had a list built entirely around brand recognition rather than fit. Or they started the process in Grade 12 and found that they had not prepared for every deadline they needed to meet.

Another feature is that Indian students are not abandoning overseas education; they are approaching it more selectively. Families are considering return on investment, employability, immigration pathways, and long-term career outcomes before deciding where to apply. In many ways, this represents a more mature admissions landscape.

Rather than applying abroad because it is perceived as the default aspiration, students are increasingly evaluating whether a particular university, country, and course genuinely align with their academic and professional goals.

Admissions reward preparation, specificity, and self-knowledge and punish last-minute scrambles and vague aspirations. That was true last cycle and will be truer in the next. The students who are best placed are the ones who started thinking about this a year or two ago. For everyone else, the second-best time to start is now.

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